on configuration). In our case above, $_SESSION has no data, and when we output the contents with the cat command, we get zero bytes. Let's see what happens when we start putting data into $_SESSION:

```
// index.php
session_start();

// if no 'visits' key in session, initialise at 0
$_SESSION['visits'] = $_SESSION['visits'] ?? 0;
$_SESSION['visits']++;

var_dump($_SESSION);
```

Now if we make a request that includes our PHPSESSID cookie, we can see how our simple $_SESSION['visits'] counter can be used to store a count of requests:

```
$ curl -v --cookie 'PHPSESSID=3fe1329aa9a3575373814ebf8aa59857' \
  http://localhost:8080/index.php
...
> GET /index.php HTTP/1.1
> Cookie: PHPSESSID=3fe1329aa9a3575373814ebf8aa59857
...
array(1) {
  ["visits"]=>
  int(1)
}
$ curl --cookie 'PHPSESSID=3fe1329aa9a3575373814ebf8aa59857' \
  http://localhost:8080/index.php
array(1) {
  ["visits"]=>
  int(2)
}
```

It was possible in earlier versions of PHP to send PHPSESSID as a query string (GET) or POST parameter if the session.use_only_cookies = 1 ini directive was not set. Setting a session ID via a URL like

```
http://localhost:8080/index.php?PHPSESSID=3fe1329aa9a3575373814ebf8aa59857
```